

Turkiye's Defence-industrial Relationships with Other European States

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September 2024



 **IISS**
The International Institute
for Strategic Studies

Acknowledgements

This paper is a part of 'National Defence Industry: From an Enabler of Turkey's Pursuit of Strategic Autonomy to a Bridge between Turkey and Europe', a joint project between the Center for Foreign Policy and Peace Research (CFPPR) and the International Institute for Strategic Studies (IISS). The project is supported by the Centre for Applied Turkey Studies (CATS).

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Cover

A T129 ATAK helicopter, based on the Leonardo A129 Mangusta, takes part in the EFES-2024 exercise, 27 May 2024

Executive Summary

Turkiye's defence-industrial relationships with key European partners have changed over time. In the 1980s Türkiye pursued joint ventures with foreign firms to procure equipment and develop defence-industrial capability. Although the most significant of these were the agreements with US firms to set up F-16 fighter-aircraft assembly in Türkiye, many projects were pursued with European companies, including for aircraft, guided weapons and communications equipment. From 2004, Türkiye changed its approach to focus more on acquiring locally developed equipment. Many of these platforms were either designed with assistance from foreign firms or were fitted with their subsystems, although over the past two decades Türkiye has been seeking to replace the latter with its own systems.

Over the last four decades, and in some cases for even longer, French, Italian, Dutch, Spanish and British companies have been important in supporting Turkish defence-industrial objectives. Today, however, some of those companies are less involved than they were previously, due to a series of political disagreements between Ankara and their respective national governments. The main causes of discord have been Türkiye's military operations in Syria since 2016, particularly the 2019 *Operation Peace Spring*, and its acquisition of the Russian Almaz-Antey S-400 air-defence system in 2017. Due to these political differences, France's and the Netherlands' levels of defence-industrial engagement with Türkiye are now at historic low points. By contrast, although Italy, Spain and the United Kingdom share many of these concerns and have at times limited defence exports to Türkiye, they largely seek to engage with Türkiye as an important NATO ally that has a key role in security matters in Europe, the Middle East and Africa. This includes seeking defence-industrial opportunities, such as the design support for Türkiye's *Anadolu* amphibious assault ship and *Kaan* fighter-aircraft programmes provided by Spanish company Navantia and the UK's BAE Systems, respectively.

Meanwhile, Türkiye's defence-industrial relationships with Eastern European states such as Poland and

Romania are in their early stages, with Türkiye the supplier of defence equipment rather than the customer. Although these countries share many policy concerns with their allies in other parts of Europe, the threat they face from Russia, which they regard as existential, has pushed them towards greater engagement with Türkiye in defence and security.

The countries analysed in this report have assessed Türkiye's defence industry to have strong capabilities, particularly in aerospace and electronics. Turkish equipment is now often combat proven, of good quality, low cost, and sold with few or no end-user restrictions. This makes Turkish products competitive on the export market against traditional suppliers. While some European companies now consider Turkish firms to be potential competitors in certain markets, other companies – particularly from Italy, Spain and the UK – see opportunities to collaborate and achieve joint success in export markets where Türkiye has sold equipment recently, such as Africa, Central Asia, the Middle East and Southeast Asia.

Turkiye's participation in the A400M transport-aircraft project is the country's most significant involvement in a European multinational programme to date. However, it is unlikely that future engagement with Türkiye will take place in a similar multinational format. Instead, efforts will probably proceed in a bilateral manner with individual countries supporting Turkish projects or collaborating with its industry to export to third countries, or with Türkiye beginning to make further export inroads with other European states. While many of the EU member states examined in this report are keen to pursue these avenues, Ankara may have to navigate a situation where EU-supported projects or initiatives designed to encourage joint procurement by members will have the effect of discouraging collaboration with Türkiye. Other avenues outside the bilateral format, such as the Organisation for Joint Armament Cooperation (OCCAR) and the NATO Support and Procurement Agency (NSPA), could represent more viable options for Türkiye.

Introduction

As Türkiye's defence-industrial capability and requirements have developed over the last four decades, its relationship with European partners has changed, with foreign companies adapting their offers over time. After initially selling off-the-shelf equipment directly from their own production lines or facilitating licensed production in Türkiye, those European companies established joint ventures (JVs) with Turkish firms to produce equipment locally through technology transfer. Then, more recently, many have moved towards providing design support or key subsystems and subcomponents for Turkish designs.

Beginning in the 1980s under the liberalising economic policies of Turgut Özal, Türkiye pursued a strategy of acquiring equipment through JVs with foreign companies. The most significant of these were the series of deals, starting in 1983, that established final assembly in Türkiye of the F-16 *Fighting Falcon* through the Turkish Aircraft Industries (now Turkish Aerospace Industries, TAI) JV between US firm General Dynamics and Turkish Aerospace (Türk Uçak Sanayii Anonim Ortaklığı, TUSAŞ).¹ In the period up to 2004, European firms from France, the Netherlands and the UK would also establish JVs with Turkish partners, either to manufacture equipment directly for the Turkish armed forces or to partner with Turkish firms in setting up production of their equipment locally. These included the licensed production of French AS532AL/UL *Cougar* helicopters, through the EUROTAI JV between TAI and Eurocopter (now Airbus Helicopters), *Rapier* air-defence systems through cooperation between BAe Dynamics (now part of MBDA) and several Turkish firms, and TAI licensed production of Construcciones Aeronáuticas (CASA) CN235 transport aircraft.

Since 2004, in order to boost defence-industrial autonomy, Türkiye has changed its approach to focus on acquiring domestically designed equipment, developed either independently or in partnership with foreign firms. Examples of the former include the MilGem corvette and the *Bayraktar* TB2 uncrewed aerial vehicle (UAV); the latter include the T129 ATAK attack helicopter developed with AgustaWestland (now

Leonardo Helicopters), Navantia's support for the TCG *Anadolu* amphibious assault vessel, and BAE Systems' design work for the *Kaan* multi-role fighter aircraft. Where Türkiye has not developed local alternatives, it has acquired foreign subsystems, for example turbojet engines for Turkish missile programmes from Microturbo, or Rolls-Royce MTU diesel engines from Germany for Turkish naval vessels.

Throughout these two periods, Türkiye has principally partnered with France, Germany, Italy, the Netherlands, Spain, the UK and the US. Israeli firms also featured from the mid-1990s to 2009, and Korean firms enjoyed some success in the Turkish market in the 2000s. More recently, a surge in exports since 2019 – initially driven by the widespread sale of armed UAVs to the Middle East and Africa, and now broadening to include other systems such as corvettes and guided weapons – has seen Türkiye engage with other countries as a supplier of its own equipment. The customers for these systems now include Eastern European countries such as Estonia, Poland and Romania, who are now beginning to engage with Türkiye as a supplier capable of meeting their defence-modernisation needs.

This report features contributions from specialists providing the perspectives of seven countries: France, Italy, the Netherlands, Poland, Romania, Spain and the UK. These states either have, have had, or could in the future have significant defence-industrial relationships with Türkiye, and examining their respective situations gives us a sense of the range of perspectives towards Türkiye among European countries. Based on a variety of sources, including interviews with industrialists and officials, the report provides an overview of these countries' defence-industrial relationships with Türkiye and how they have changed over time. It also discusses how those countries perceive Türkiye's defence-industrial capability, and how their respective degrees of political friction with Ankara impact defence cooperation. Finally, the report looks at how Türkiye is seen as either a potential defence partner or as a competitor for exports, or both.

1. Türkiye's Bilateral Defence-industrial Relationships with Other European States

France and the UK have long histories of defence-industrial engagement with Türkiye as suppliers of equipment, dating back to the Ottoman period, while Italy, the Netherlands and Spain began their defence-industrial relationships with Türkiye at different points in the last 50 years. Whereas Italian, Spanish and UK companies continue to seek opportunities in Türkiye, French and Dutch engagement appears either to be waning or at a standstill. By contrast, Turkish companies have been interested in the Polish and Romanian markets for some time but only recently secured their first successes: the *Bayraktar* TB2 UAV was sold to Poland in 2021 and to Romania in 2023, with deals for sales of other types of equipment to Romania likely to follow soon.

Many officials and industrialists in the states featured in this report acknowledge the rapid pace of Türkiye's defence-industrial development and speak of its competencies in the aerospace and defence-electronics sectors in particular, as well as the broader engineering skills that the Turkish workforce possesses. The Defence Industry Agency (Savunma Sanayii Başkanlığı, SSB), Türkiye's procurement organisation, is assessed to be key to this process not only in terms of managing programmes but also through its leading role in planning the broader defence-industrial effort. However, concerns about aggressive offset requirements, political influence in the procurement process and unpredictable or controversial actions in the foreign-policy sphere act as constraints on many companies' engagement with Türkiye.

Generally, despite the increasing difficulties due to foreign-policy divergences, Türkiye is viewed as a valuable NATO ally with a key role in security dynamics in the Balkans, the Black Sea, Eastern Europe and the Middle East. European partners appreciated Türkiye's closing of the Bosphorus and Dardanelles straits to foreign warships in February 2022, and its role in facilitating the Black Sea grain deal in July 2022. Also, in some European states, changes in policy towards formal

recognition of a Palestinian state may see greater alignment with Türkiye on that issue going forward.

As for the foreign-policy disagreements, all states in this report took issue with Türkiye's acquisition of the Russian S-400 (RS-SA-21 *Growler*) surface-to-air missile (SAM) system in 2017, which appeared to mark a movement away from NATO allies in Ankara's foreign-policy and defence trajectories. Since the 2016 coup attempt, the Turkish government has adopted a more assertive foreign policy that has often sought to deal with security threats through military means. A prime example is Türkiye's operations in northeastern Syria since 2016, particularly the *Operation Peace Spring* mission in 2019, which have also strained ties with other European states. Some countries, such as France, have chosen to make public their disagreements with Ankara, whereas others, such as the UK, have opted to keep disagreements private in the hope of having a more constructive relationship. Other areas of concern include Türkiye's bilateral relationship with Russia more broadly, its slowness in ratifying Sweden's NATO candidacy, its military activity in Libya, and its energy exploration in the Eastern Mediterranean. *Operation Peace Spring* and the gas exploration resulted in many European states restricting export licences to Türkiye for several years, often on a case-by-case basis.

Eastern European states such as Poland and Romania are also concerned with some of these issues, but because of their geographical proximity to Russia and the existential threat they perceive, security issues in Eastern Europe and the Black Sea have taken precedence in their respective dialogues with Ankara. Because of this, Poland and Romania see their current bilateral relations with Türkiye as largely positive and constructive, and there are hopes that a trilateral format may emerge even if many bilateral defence-industrial initiatives have yet to take off.

Turkish defence equipment is widely seen as being affordable and of increasingly good quality. Also, it has few end-user restrictions, and in many cases it

is combat proven. These factors combine to make it attractive on the export market and mean that even if Turkish designs are not judged to be of the same technical quality as some of their European competitors, they are still competitive. Over the last five years Türkiye has enjoyed significant success with UAV exports, and a growing portfolio in other domains, such as land and naval systems, could mean greater competition for European companies going forward. However, there are also opportunities for Turkish and other European companies to combine expertise, some of which are currently being exploited. For example, in 2024, Otokar and Leonardo have showcased a light-tank offer. At the same time, foreign companies remain concerned about Türkiye's aggressive offset policies, the potential for political interference when privately owned companies have been contracted, high inflation, a 'brain drain' causing highly trained Turkish staff to leave the country, and an unpredictable foreign policy that can make long-term engagement more difficult.

Italy, Spain and the UK are the European countries most open to supporting Turkish defence-modernisation ambitions, and the most able to do so. Companies from those three countries are also the most disposed to collaborate with Turkish firms in seeking opportunities in other markets. However, these initiatives would probably be on a bilateral basis and there is no sense at present that they would be multinational programmes aimed at meeting the equipment requirements of all parties, like the A400M transport-aircraft programme in which Türkiye participates with six other European countries. The proposed Eurofighter *Typhoon* deal would represent a rare sale of equipment to Ankara from a foreign production line and would be a major investment by Türkiye in its defence relationships with Italy, Spain and

the UK, as well as with Germany. In a reverse of those dynamics, Poland and Romania, particularly the latter, see potential for Türkiye to support their own defence and industrial needs, although so far there is little to show for it.

Another likely avenue will be partnerships at the industrial level whereby Turkish companies are included in the supply chains of other European companies and vice versa. Here, some countries, such as the UK, see mutual benefit in partnering with Türkiye to exploit each other's technical strengths and to build on each other's success in selling to certain other countries. Türkiye's recent sales to countries in Africa, Central Asia and Southeast Asia are seen as presenting such opportunities.

The EU member states analysed in this report strongly support recent EU initiatives to encourage joint procurement and strengthen the 'European defence technological and industrial base', which naturally includes their own firms.² It is likely that such mechanisms will continue and be expanded in the future, as proposed by the EU Commission. This represents a problem for Türkiye, and other non-members of the EU, as it may shift the incentives for member states away from cooperating with third parties even if, as in the case of Romania, they are keen to work more closely with Türkiye. There are other avenues however, such as the six-nation Organisation for Joint Armament Cooperation (OCCAR), the defence-programme-management body through which Türkiye has acquired the A400M, and NATO, through the NATO Support and Procurement Agency (NSPA).³ These could be more viable options for Ankara in terms of other avenues for partnering with European states on equipment programmes, outside the purely bilateral approaches.

2. France

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Franco-Turkish relations in the field of armaments have a long historical background that dates back to the late Ottoman period, although they were interrupted by the two world wars. More recently, French defence exports to Türkiye have been extensive both in terms of quantity and variety, reflecting the broad capabilities of France's defence industry.

In the land domain, French industry has been contracted to support Turkish armoured-vehicle and guided-weapon programmes. A contract for the delivery of 515 *Dragar* vehicle turrets and 575 M-811 25mm cannons was concluded in 1992 between GIAT and Turkish company FNSS, a JV between Nurol Holding and US firm FMC, whose defence business is now part of BAE Systems.⁴ The turrets and cannons were manufactured under licence by, respectively, Nurol and the Mechanical and Chemical Industry Corporation (Makine ve Kimya Endüstrisi, MKE). However, the programme experienced manufacturing difficulties, such as the discovery of cracks on the turrets. Similarly, starting in 1998, MKE produced 19,200 *Eryx* anti-tank missiles and 1,600 launchers under licence from Aérospatiale. However, according to Turkish sources, some of the munitions were defective and did not reach their targets, resulting in Türkiye terminating the contract.

In the maritime domain, Türkiye acquired a variety of ships that had previously been in service with the French Navy, before it developed a more capable naval shipbuilding industry able to construct its own designs. In the 1970s, seven French-built mine-countermeasures vessels were transferred to Türkiye by France and Germany. Five *Circé*-class minehunters were acquired by the Turkish Naval Forces (TNF) between 1998 and 1999, followed by six *D'Estienne d'Orves*-class corvettes between 2000 and 2002. More recently, Türkiye contracted Thales in 2002 to provide nine AMASCOS maritime-surveillance systems for the CN235 aircraft-based

Meltem II programme: six of them for TNF and three for the Turkish Coast Guard. The TNF's follow-on *Meltem* III programme, based on Italian ATR-72 aircraft and contracted in 2008, saw Thales deliver a further ten AMASCOS systems. However, *Meltem* II was delayed by five years, resulting in Türkiye imposing financial penalties on Thales.

The wide variety extends to the aerospace domain. In the 1990s, Eurocopter sold 50 AS532 *Cougar* helicopters in two separate contracts: 20 AS532UL *Cougar* Mk 1 helicopters in 1993 for the Turkish Army's Phénix 1 programme and 30 AS532AL/UL *Cougar* Mk 1s in 1997 for the air force and army's Phénix 2 programme. The latter programme saw TAI produce most of the helicopters under licence. Also, 14 French TRS-22XX deployable radars were produced between 1992 and 1997 by the JV between Thomson Tekfen Radar Sanayi ve Ticaret (TTR) (now Havelsan Teknoloji Radar (HTR)) and Thomson-CSF (now Thales). Elsewhere, from 2007, Thales contributed to the development of the T129 ATAK attack helicopter with its *TopOwl Helmet-Mounted Sight & Display* in partnership with ASELSAN.

Since the 1970s the Turkish Air Force has operated the Franco-German C-160D *Transall* (although the aircraft were acquired from Germany rather than France), which it is now replacing with A400M heavy airlifters. France, through Aérospatiale, had a significant role in the efforts that led to that aircraft, with Türkiye committing in the late 1990s to acquire ten A400Ms. The ten aircraft included in the 2003 production contract were subsequently delivered between 2013 and 2022. The A400M represents the most significant multinational programme featuring both Paris and Ankara, and is managed through OCCAR.

In the space domain, French companies, with Italian partners, have manufactured satellites for commercial and/or military use for Türkiye for about 30 years, going

back to the *Türksat-1* series of communications satellites built by Aérospatiale in the 1990s. In 2009 Türkiye signed a contract with the Franco-Italian JV Telespazio for the development of the *Göktürk-1* optical-observation satellite, in which another Franco-Italian JV, Thales Alenia Space, was also involved.⁵ Significantly, on the Turkish side, the firms involved included ASELSAN, Roketsan and TAI. Two *Türksat-5* communications satellites launched in 2021 have taken this a step further, with an ASELSAN payload integrated into an Airbus satellite bus in Toulouse.

One significant area of recent cooperation has been air and missile defence. Türkiye launched the Improved Long-range Air-defence System/Long-range Regional Air- and Missile-defence System (Geliştirilmiş Uzun Menzilli (Hava Savunma) Sistemi/Uzun Menzilli Bölgesel Hava ve Füze Savunma Sistemi, GUMS/UMBHFSS) programme in 2016 through ASELSAN and Roketsan. In parallel, these companies partnered with Eurosam, a JV between Thales and the French and Italian elements of MBDA, on the development of a new high-altitude missile-defence system, with Türkiye awarding a definition study contract to the three companies in 2018.⁶ Public announcements at that time stated that the intention was for this to lead to a joint three-nation programme that would be ready for operations by the mid-2020s. This cooperation work continues but has not yet

yielded results, following on from the failure of the sale of Eurosam's SAMP/T air-defence system and Türkiye's acquisition of the S-400.

The strength of Türkiye's defence industry lies in its centralised organisation and planning. With the SSB placed under the direct responsibility of the Presidency of the Republic since 2018, the needs expressed by the armed forces are taken into consideration at the highest level of the state and are subject to a rigorous planning system. This structure has contributed to a rapid increase in the number of equipment projects: in 2002 there were 62 but in 2024 there are more than 1,000, collectively worth USD96 billion, according to President Erdoğan.⁷ Many of these systems are combat proven and the prices remain affordable. This has resulted in increased exports, with 230 types of equipment sold to 185 countries in 2023 for a total of USD5.5bn, according to official figures.⁸

With regard to many systems, however, Türkiye has not yet achieved complete technological mastery because they are being manufactured through technology transfer. Türkiye declares that it is largely autonomous in its defence-industrial capability, with 85% of its defence equipment manufactured domestically according to official figures, but it still depends on foreign firms for some advanced technologies, such as engines and missile-defence capabilities.⁹

A Turkish Army AS532 Cougar takes part in an exercise in Northern Cyprus, June 2019



(ADEM ALTAN/AFP via Getty Images)

In Paris, Türkiye does not inspire political confidence. There are many frictions between the two countries, such as over recognition of the Armenian genocide and French concerns about human rights. Having engaged more closely with Armenia and Greece in recent years, France no longer has a high-level dialogue with Türkiye on armaments issues. And since Türkiye's 2019 *Operation Peace Spring* in northeastern Syria, France has approved export licences on a case-by-case basis, due mainly to fears that equipment will be transferred to third parties. As for the sale of weapons systems to Türkiye, France no longer authorises them. As a result, Türkiye only ranked 30th among the buyers of French arms exports during the period 2013–22.¹⁰

Today, bilateral cooperation between the French and Turkish governments on weapons programmes is close to zero. French small and medium-sized enterprises therefore have the best sales potential either directly or in partnership with Turkish companies, especially if their activities do not require export authorisation. The most significant exchanges take place within the framework of NATO, but French companies participate

regularly in arms fairs in Türkiye, and vice versa, and there are also some partnership mechanisms between professional groups. There is potential for cooperation and export opportunities in the aerospace sector, including sharing lessons learned during UAV operations, and also in meeting Türkiye's requirement for a replacement for its KC-135R *Stratotanker* tanker aircraft. It is possible that cooperation in these areas will help to improve broader relations between the two countries.

When it comes to competition between French and Turkish defence exporters, it is notable that the latter do not face the numerous restrictions and onerous processes involved in the granting of export licences in France. The land sector is the principal arena for competition, given the extensive portfolio of systems the Turkish defence industry has developed. Turkish companies are currently judged not to be matching the technical level of their French counterparts in the naval, aerospace (with the exception of UAVs) and space sectors. The same is true of the Turkish defence-electronics sector, despite recent progress by companies such as ASELSAN and HAVELSAN.

3. Italy

Andrea Gilli, Lecturer, University of St Andrews & Mauro Gilli, Senior Researcher, ETH-Zurich

Since the 1967 Cyprus crisis and the embargoes on Türkiye that followed its 1974 invasion of Northern Cyprus, Italy has become a leading supplier of military equipment to Türkiye. In 2022, Türkiye was the leading destination for Italian defence-export authorisations (EUR598.2m (USD630.43m)), and the sixth in 2023 (EUR231.3m (USD250.17m)).¹¹ These sales have largely consisted of the delivery of four types of matériel: aircraft, particularly helicopters (such as the ATR-72 turboprop aircraft and the AW109, AB-212/412 and T129 ATAK attack helicopters); naval guns (such as Oto Melara's series of 76mm systems); military and dual-use satellites (often through French–Italian JVs); and guided weapons for naval vessels (such as the A244 lightweight torpedo and the *Aspide* SAM). Italian industry has also supplied subsystems for Turkish systems that are then exported to third parties, such as Leonardo's *Osprey* 30 radars for the *Bayraktar* TB2 UAVs purchased by Poland.¹² These transfers have typically been processed through two types of programme: direct sale from an Italian production line (as in the case of the AB-212/412) or licensed production of a Turkish version of an Italian design (the *Dost*-class coastguard patrol ships and the T129 ATAK helicopter, for example).

Defence-industrial relations between Italy and Türkiye are seen in broadly positive terms. However, observers stress that political dynamics have often played an important role in shaping those relations. The success of the Italy–Türkiye partnership, and also the surrounding dynamics, is probably best illustrated by the ATAK programme.

After the programme was launched in 1996 with a request for proposals (RFP) for 145 attack helicopters through licensed production, Italy's AgustaWestland was initially unsuccessful, partly because of a political crisis between Rome and Ankara over Italy's refusal to extradite Abdullah Öcalan, the then-leader of the Kurdistan

Workers' Party (Partiya Karkerên Kurdistanê, PKK), during his brief stay in the country in 1998–99. The situation soon changed, however. Türkiye became an official candidate for EU membership in 1999, and in 2001 the newly elected Italian government of Silvio Berlusconi threw its weight behind the candidacy. Following the cancellation of the first ATAK programme, a new RFP was issued in 2006; AgustaWestland emerged as the winner with its A129 *Mangusta*, and in 2007 Türkiye contracted TAI for the first batch of T129 helicopters.

The ATAK program is largely seen as a success because of the significant transfer of technology, made possible by Türkiye's solid science and technology base and the close working relations between Italian and Turkish engineers, and because of the T129's export successes in Nigeria and the Philippines. The programme played a major part in establishing the Turkish helicopter industry, which now works on indigenous designs such as *Gökbeş*.

Other successful projects in recent years have included Fincantieri supporting Turkish construction of four *Dost*-class patrol ships for the Turkish Coast Guard; the work by Vitrociset, now part of Leonardo, on a digital data-acquisition system, on command and communication centres, and in consulting for the Turkish space programme; and Leonardo's provision of technologies for maritime and airborne traffic control.¹³

Because of this record of success, Italian industrialists and officials view Türkiye as an attractive market. This is due to several factors, including strong growth in Turkish defence spending; a solid science and technology base, with significant investment in defence electronics; and Turkish experience in working through JVs and with foreign partners. Türkiye's defence-procurement agency, the SSB, is well regarded by Italian officials who have experience of working with it.

However, these positives are balanced by concerns about Türkiye's limited research-and-development



(Orhan Cicek/Anadolu via Getty Images)

(R&D) budget, which is spread across many projects, and the significant demands regarding intellectual property rights, technology transfer and industrial returns that Türkiye demands when negotiating deals. Furthermore, many interlocutors privately assessed that political connections sometimes play an important role in determining contracts involving private-sector companies. This poses a risk to Italian companies, as a Turkish company that they engage with could subsequently fall out of favour. Several interlocutors were also unsure whether Türkiye will be able to maintain its strong defence-spending growth, given rampant inflation rates and the fiscal pressure caused by socio-economic issues that may require additional funding. Türkiye's growing defence exports to, and broader engagement with, states in Africa, Central Asia and the Middle East might also create risk, depending on how those systems are used.

On many issues, such as concerns over Turkish support for Azerbaijan's offensive in Nagorno-Karabakh, Italy shares the same ambitions, goals and interests as its EU partners. Italy often seems content to let other European states take the lead on contentious areas with Türkiye, and therefore its disagreements with Türkiye can be understood within that broader context. However, some of these issues – such as the earlier stages of the civil war in Libya, or energy exploration in the Eastern Mediterranean – are deeper or more acute,

and impinge more directly on Italian security concerns.

Some divergences between Italy and Türkiye – such as on relations with Israel, and Turkish activity in the Horn of Africa – do not seem to affect defence-industrial relations. Others, however, have major implications. This has been the case, for example, with Türkiye's acquisition of the Russian S-400 air-defence system; Türkiye's operations in Libya and Syria, which led to the interruption of some projects and the derailing of others, as in the case of Italian and French cooperation with Türkiye on air and missile-defence; concerns about potential arms exports from Türkiye to third countries; and Türkiye's slowness to ratify Sweden's NATO accession. All these factors have influenced Italian views about Türkiye's participation in future NATO and multinational defence projects.¹⁴ Also, the two countries are simultaneously seeking to exert influence in Africa and the Eastern Mediterranean, although in some respects their interests align – Italy sees the Turkish military presence in Libya as a stabilising factor, for example, and both countries have a strong interest in the territorial integrity of Somalia.

Many Italian industrialists and officials believe there is scope to further expand defence-industrial relations, citing Türkiye's recent defence-budget growth, its capability ambitions, and the defence-industrial capability gaps that could be filled or at least partly addressed by foreign partners. Areas of potential cooperation include

maritime search and rescue and underwater critical-infrastructure security. Given that Italy has a leading naval defence industry, and that Italy and Türkiye are both Mediterranean powers, there would appear to be potential for further cooperation in that sector. However, according to some observers, the significant degree of interdependence between the Italian and French naval defence industries could represent a political barrier, given the more complicated relations between Ankara and Paris. An example of recent cooperation, in 2024, is the unveiling of a light tank by Leonardo and Otokar, combining the former's turret with the latter's vehicle.¹⁵

Furthermore, the Italian Air Force is seeking to acquire Roketsan *Cirit* laser-guided rockets as part of its planned acquisition of Leonardo's *Astore* UAVs, in a rare example of a potential Turkish defence export to a major European defence-industrial country.¹⁶ As for competition from Türkiye, the view from the industrialists and officials is that the Turkish defence industry is focused largely on sectors and markets different from those where Italian companies' efforts are concentrated. One possible exception, however, is the lucrative Middle East market, where Türkiye's greater willingness to transfer technology may give its companies a competitive advantage.

4. The Netherlands

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To date, the defence-industrial relationship between the Netherlands and Türkiye has generally been limited. Other than the sale of second-hand fighter aircraft, bilateral trade in this sector has been largely limited to the sale to Türkiye of Thales Nederland fire-control and air-search radars, such as the SMART-S, STIR, WM-25 and WM-28, for Turkish naval vessels.¹⁷ In 1996 the TNF established a software-development centre and sent engineers to work with Signaal (now Thales Nederland) on combat-management systems, forming the basis of Türkiye's current know-how in that area.¹⁸ In the land domain, in the 1990s there was the sale of infantry-fighting-vehicle turrets, supplied by DAF for some of the vehicles in Türkiye's Armoured Combat Vehicle (Zırhlı Muharebe Aracı, ZMA) project. These are now being replaced by a Turkish alternative.¹⁹ Technology-transfer arrangements as part of these deals have contributed to the improvement of Turkish defence-industrial capabilities, with ASELSAN locally producing the SMART-S air-surveillance radar for MilGem corvettes, among other platforms, and having been integrated into the Thales Nederland supply chain for the system.²⁰ In the other direction, there are almost no Dutch imports of Turkish defence equipment: the last purchase of note was a 2005 deal to buy a small batch of *Pedestal Mounted Stinger* air-defence systems from ASELSAN, to be fitted onto Royal Netherlands Army *Fennek* armoured vehicles.²¹ The current generation of Turkish naval vessels are now being fitted with Turkish-sourced sensors instead of the Dutch systems used on previous classes.²² Even the limited defence-equipment trade that does still exist, then, appears to be waning.

The broader relationship between The Hague and Ankara has been strained for years by a wide range of issues. These include how Europe and Türkiye handle refugees fleeing conflicts in the Middle East; Türkiye's EU candidacy, along with the wider EU–Türkiye

relationship; Ankara's refusal to recognise the Republic of Cyprus; Dutch legislative recognition of the Armenian genocide; and tensions related to President Erdoğan's Justice and Development Party (Adalet ve Kalkınma Partisi, AKP) campaigning among the Turkish diaspora in the Netherlands. On specific defence and security issues, the Netherlands has regularly opposed Türkiye's military operations in Syria since 2016 and Ankara's support of Azerbaijan's offensive in Nagorno-Karabakh in 2020. Much of the Dutch–Turkish defence relationship is mediated by shared membership in NATO.

The two countries' limited defence-industrial relations were frozen following the 2019 *Operation Peace Spring* offensive into northeastern Syria. The Netherlands joined other EU member states in effectively suspending arms exports to Türkiye through a comprehensive 'presumption of denial' approach to any sale of materiel.²³ As a result, the already-low value of defence-export licences issued by the Netherlands for sales to Türkiye totalled a measly EUR4.23m (USD4.56m) during 2020–22.²⁴ This restriction was lifted in the summer of 2023, largely as part of a normalisation of relations following Russia's invasion of Ukraine but also partially in service of Dutch ambitions to join the 2021 France–Germany–Spain arms-control agreement.²⁵ There is a politically powerful lobby in the Netherlands against closer defence-industrial ties with Türkiye, represented in large part by the Foundation for the Campaign Against the Arms Trade (Stichting Campagne tegen Wapenhandel) pressure group. The anti-arms-exports groups in the Netherlands are far more politically salient than in many other NATO states and actively lobby parties in parliament, although they have limited influence on those currently in government. Türkiye has been a particular target of this campaigning, with the Erdoğan government's human-rights record being the main point of contention.²⁶

In 2022, the Advisory Council on International Affairs (Adviesraad Internationale Vraagstukken, AIV) an independent body that provides analysis and information to both the government and parliament, authored a report that urged the government to conduct a thorough review of its relations with Ankara.²⁷ The main driver of the advice, unsurprisingly, was the Russian invasion of Ukraine. In the advice, improved bilateral defence relations were raised, though heavily caveated in light of the above-mentioned tensions. It noted that Turkish involvement in either the Permanent Structured Cooperation (PESCO) projects or in any substantive EU–NATO cooperation is a non-starter due to the Cyprus issue, which is unlikely to change soon. However, the AIV did argue that the EU’s Schuman Forum on defence and security partnerships, established in 2023, could be a way to begin improving relations and discussing issues, and Turkish representatives did in fact take part in the second iteration in 2024.²⁸

In its response to the AIV report, the Dutch cabinet concurred with the overall finding that while better overall relations with Ankara do need to be a priority

in Dutch foreign policy, the wider political issues in the relationship are preventing improvements in the bilateral defence relationship. The government also noted that Türkiye’s use of the Russian S-400 air-defence system was an additional barrier to greater Dutch interest in military exports and collaborative projects, due to concerns regarding technological security.²⁹

This advisory exchange preceded both the lifting of export restrictions and the latest Dutch election in 2023. Under the new government of Prime Minister Dick Schoof there is a possible opening for some improved bilateral defence-industrial cooperation. As the government is prioritising issues of asylum by increasing resources and revisiting the legal regime surrounding asylum policies, this could open doors to improved practical relations with Ankara given Türkiye’s lynchpin role in that area. However, defence-industrial relations will remain only a subset of the two countries’ broader relations, which will continue to face major structural hurdles.

The Dutch defence industry has remained hesitant about exploring new opportunities to export to

An *Ada*-class MilGem corvette, TCG *Kınalıada*, arrives in Tokyo, 12 June 2024. The class of vessels is fitted with Thales Nederland SMART-S and *Sting* EO Mk2 radars.



(Berkan Cetin/Anadolu via Getty Images)

Turkiye. One apparent indicator of this is the fact that the Netherlands Industries for Defence & Security (Nederlandse Industrie voor Defensie en Veiligheid, NIDV), an industry representative body, has no publicly available materials related to exporting to or collaborating with Türkiye and its defence industry. This is unlikely to change without a more positive intergovernmental signal, such as a Dutch–Turkish memorandum of understanding on which longer-term defence planning and manufacturing decisions could be based. It should also be noted that the Netherlands is a strong supporter of the new European Defence Industrial Strategy, published in 2024, which has an explicit aim of reducing member states’ dependence on third-country suppliers of defence materiel in favour of procuring

from other members.³⁰ There is not, therefore, a positive investment environment that might encourage Dutch companies to look far outside their immediate neighbourhood for markets.

Another issue is that several Dutch and Turkish companies, principally in the shipbuilding and sensor sectors, are now competitors in the export market. Damen Shipyards Group and Thales Nederland have effective monopolies in the Netherlands itself and have longstanding relationships with Belgium, Germany and the United Kingdom. However, Dutch exports further afield, particularly to Gulf states and in the maritime-subsystem market, will probably become more competitive as Turkish companies seek to expand their business there, often with government backing.

5. Poland

**Konrad Zasztowt, Assistant Professor,
Warsaw University**

Although there have been attempts for over three decades to start projects, defence-industrial cooperation between Poland and Türkiye is still in its early stages. Turkish industry has shown great interest in the Polish market, and company representatives have been present at Poland's annual International Defence Industry Exhibition (Międzynarodowy Salon Przemysłu Obronnego, MSPO) every year since the event began in 1993. Moreover, Türkiye is the only country in the history of the MSPO to have appeared at the fair twice (in 2013 and 2022) as the official leading exhibitor, which is to say the country with the largest presence.³¹ In 2022, Türkiye's and Poland's defence ministers, Hulusi Akar and Mariusz Błaszczak, made a joint visit to the event.

Talks between Polish and Turkish defence-industry representatives have ranged over several potential fields of cooperation. In most cases this has involved Turkish companies offering to meet Polish objectives such as the acquisition of air- and missile-defence systems, UAVs and helicopters (such as the Turkish T129 ATAK); the acquisition and upgrade of new submarines; *Arma 6x6* armoured vehicles; satellite reconnaissance systems; the modernisation of frigates and *Leopard 2A4* tanks; and servicing and logistics related to the F-16 and C-130 *Hercules* aircraft.³²

Poland has also considered cooperation in the production of guided anti-tank and anti-aircraft missiles, including for the modernisation of its Mi-24 *Hind* attack helicopters, and the purchase of hulls for *Krab* tracked howitzers from a Turkish manufacturer, but the projects did not go ahead.³³ Memoranda of understanding have been signed between Polish and Turkish companies, such as MESKO and Wojskowe Zakłady Lotnicze No. 1 on the Polish side, and ASELSAN, Roketsan and TAI on the Turkish.³⁴ Roketsan, for instance, has expressed interest in participating in Poland's *Homar* multiple rocket launcher (MRL) programme, offering a guided 122mm rocket for the Polish WR-40 *Langusta* in 2017 at

the MSPO, but without success.³⁵ Overall, most Turkish companies have had little to show for their efforts.

One of the reasons for the lack of implementation of proposed Polish–Turkish modernisation projects is the Polish armed forces' abandonment (gradual until 2022, but more rapid since then) of Soviet-era equipment that was to be improved with the help of Turkish companies. Poland transferred much of that equipment to Ukraine after the full-scale Russian invasion in February 2022.³⁶ Also, in recent years, successive Polish governments have prioritised cooperation with companies from the United States, the UK and, since 2022, South Korea.

So far, Poland–Türkiye defence-industrial cooperation has been mostly limited to Poland's procurement of Turkish UAVs. During a visit to Türkiye by President Andrzej Duda in 2021, in the presence of President Erdoğan, Poland contracted Baykar to supply 24 *Bayraktar* TB2 UAVs for approximately USD268m.³⁷ Deliveries have been made on schedule since 2022, accompanied by ground-control stations, Leonardo *Osprey* 30 active electronically scanned array radars, simulators, and a training, logistics and weapons package.³⁸ The Polish government's decision to purchase the *Bayraktars* was influenced by having seen the capability of the TB2 UAVs in combat, but there was also a political context: a desire to deepen bilateral cooperation with Türkiye. More recently, Warsaw has hoped to step up the trilateral discussions with Türkiye and Romania that started in 2012.³⁹ These discussions are an important element of Poland's strategy to strengthen cooperation between the countries on NATO's eastern flank.⁴⁰

As well as their geographical position on the eastern edge of NATO, Poland and Türkiye also share views on issues such as support for the territorial integrity of states. On the other hand, the two countries have different threat perceptions. While the greatest threat to Poland remains Russia, for Türkiye the conflicts in the Middle East, including the current wars in Gaza and

The first batch of Bayraktar TB2 UAVs is delivered to Poland, 28 October 2022



(Polish Ministry of Defense/Handout/Anadolu Agency via Getty Images)

Syria, are more important. At the same time, successive governments in Warsaw, both the United Right led by Mateusz Morawiecki (prime minister from 2017–23) and the Civic Coalition of Donald Tusk (prime minister since 2023), have maintained good relations with Ankara, and Poland remains one of the biggest supporters of Türkiye's accession to the EU. None of the Polish political parties is openly critical of Ankara's Middle Eastern policy or its policy towards the Kurdish minority. This distinguishes Poland from Scandinavian countries such as Sweden and Finland, which have significant Kurdish immigrant populations and whose governments emphasise human-rights issues, which have often been a problem in their relations with Türkiye.

In recent years Poland's leaders have begun to pay more attention to the role of the defence industry as

a potential driver of economic growth and one of the most important guarantors of national security. Polish companies have been involved in a variety of modernisation projects across different sectors, with local workshare and technology transfer prized in deals with foreign firms.⁴¹ It is likely that the new government will concentrate less on acquiring equipment off the shelf from the United States and more on cooperating with other European companies – especially French and German ones, given the current revival of the Weimar Triangle format (France–Germany–Poland).⁴² Poland has also invested heavily in South Korean defence equipment, with industrial workshare included in the deals. However, shared security interests in Eastern Europe and the Black Sea could create opportunities for Poland–Türkiye defence collaboration going forward.

6. Romania

Simona R. Soare, Professor of Strategy and Technology, Lancaster University

Romania and Türkiye are close trading partners, with Romania the fourth-largest buyer of Turkish exports in 2023 (USD627.7m).⁴³ Bucharest and Ankara are allies in NATO and share a common interest in the stability and security of the Black Sea, Georgia, Moldova, Ukraine and the Western Balkans. Yet this remains an incomplete and imperfect partnership, and Romanian political leaders have occasionally acknowledged its limitations. Within NATO, as well as on a regional level, Bucharest and Ankara share important security, energy and trade interests, even if the two capitals do not always share the same views on relations with Russia, the Israel–Palestine conflict, counter-terrorism efforts in the Middle East, or European restrictions on defence-industrial cooperation with Türkiye.

Within this context, defence-industrial collaboration has not proceeded at the same pace as other areas of cooperation. This is explained both by structural factors, such as Romania's underdeveloped and under-resourced defence industry and Bucharest's off-the-shelf approach to defence procurement, and strategic factors related to the consolidation of the partnership between Romania and the US, Germany and Israel in the last three decades. But things may be about to change. Both sides hope that a growing bilateral trade and greater security cooperation – including through the trilateral security-consultation framework between Romania, Poland and Türkiye, initiated in 2012, and the trilateral demining initiative in the Black Sea – can form the basis for more success going forward.⁴⁴

Since 2022, Romania–Türkiye bilateral efforts have sought to broaden defence-industrial cooperation. In October 2023, on the celebration of 100 years of military relations between the two countries, they signed a framework agreement on military cooperation. This came amid a series of reciprocal visits between Romanian and Turkish high-level officials, which had started in 2022.⁴⁵ The agreement is described as 'reflect[ing] the current level of military relations' between the two countries, but specific follow-up actions are yet to be defined.

Bucharest is particularly interested in collaboration that incorporates significant technology-transfer and localised-production elements, although low margins and tough contract conditions on the Romanian side have been obstacles in Romanian procurement and collaboration efforts in the past.⁴⁶ One example is the memorandum of understanding signed in late 2022 by the Romanian state-owned defence company, Romarm, and the Turkish defence company ASELSAN.⁴⁷ This is expected to enable Romarm to acquire the technology to produce guided weapons, including for air-defence systems and Romanian *Piranha V* infantry fighting vehicles.⁴⁸ The 2023 procurement of 18 *Bayraktar* TB2 UAVs, worth USD321m, and the ongoing negotiations over the procurement of 1,059 light armoured vehicles, worth up to ROM4.58bn (USD1bn), for which Otokar is the only bidder with its *Cobra II*, are more concrete examples of recent Turkish–Romanian defence-industrial engagement.⁴⁹

The most recent Romanian efforts to develop defence-industrial cooperation with Türkiye are driven mainly by changes in the regional security environment following Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine in February 2022 and by Romania's defence-modernisation programme, which includes expanding the capabilities of the Romanian defence industry. Furthermore, Romanian overtures to Türkiye come against the background of the rapid development of the Turkish defence industry and Bucharest's efforts to diversify its defence procurement towards newcomers in the market.

Starting with the signature of the bilateral strategic partnership between the two countries in 2011, both the centre-right and centre-left Romanian governments, and more broadly the Romanian parliament, have supported efforts to engage Türkiye in more meaningful defence-industrial cooperation. Since 2022, high-level Romanian officials have repeatedly restated the key role of Türkiye in the region and emphasised that it is one of Romania's most important regional strategic partners.⁵⁰



(Marek Antoni Iwanczuk/SOPA Images/LightRocket via Getty Images)

In May 2024, during a joint press conference with President Erdoğan, Romanian Prime Minister Marcel Ciolacu argued that Romania wanted ‘closer cooperation with Türkiye in two domains which it considers strategic, namely the defence industry and energy’.⁵¹ In June, the defence minister, Angel Tilvar, underlined Bucharest’s commitment to enhancing defence-industrial collaboration with Ankara as a means to achieve the country’s defence and industrial goals.⁵²

It is notable that these steps forward are quite new. In the defence-industrial arena over the last two decades, the relationship between Romania and Türkiye has been sporadic, featuring more failures than successes. In the period 2014–15, for example, there were unsuccessful attempts by Bucharest to engage Ankara in the upgrade and modernisation of 12 F-16 *Fighting Falcon* fighter aircraft acquired from Portugal, the upgrade of *Gepard* air-defence systems, and technological cooperation in the development of UAVs. The contract to upgrade the Romanian F-16s was eventually won by Lockheed Martin.⁵³

More broadly, however, Romania has shown a willingness to expand its relationships beyond traditional partners such as France, Germany, Israel and the US. For example, turning down rival Western bids, in 2023 Romania acquired Turkish *Bayraktar* TB2 UAVs (see above), and in July 2024 it announced it had signed a USD1.04bn contract with South

Korea’s Hanwha Aerospace for the procurement of 54 K9 self-propelled howitzers.⁵⁴ The latter contract includes local production, technology transfer and the creation of a facility for maintenance, repair and overhaul.⁵⁵ From Romania’s perspective, it is usually the price point that has given these new suppliers their competitive edge.

Bucharest is pragmatically seeking to consolidate foreign investment in and technology transfer to its defence industry, with a view to increasing local production and capability. This is largely because in recent years many prospective investment contracts for Romania have gone instead to its neighbour Hungary. Romania has also initiated collaboration efforts with Türkiye and South Korea, which it regards as two examples of rapid defence-industrial development, and there has been some progress in that respect. But in the last three years Bucharest has also been aiming to increase engagement with other, more traditional defence suppliers, such as US, German, French and Israeli companies. Furthermore, as cooperation intensifies in the EU context through the deployment of common funding for R&D and joint procurement of munitions, Bucharest will have greater financial incentives to enhance cooperation with European, American and Israeli partners that have agreed defence-industrial cooperation frameworks with the EU. The fact that Ankara has not done so will be a disincentive to work with Turkish companies.

7. Spain

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Turkiye is one of the most attractive markets for Spanish defence manufacturers, with Spain authorising exports of military equipment worth EUR6.11bn (USD6.59bn) from 2013 to 2022, including EUR1.18bn (USD1.28bn) in 2022 alone.⁵⁶ The vast majority of this value has been related to the multinational A400M heavy transport aircraft, which is assembled in Spain. Broader trade between the two states is projected to reach EUR20bn (USD21.57bn) by 2024.⁵⁷ Spanish defence companies, such as Navantia, have collaborated extensively with Turkish firms on naval projects, including the construction of the *Anadolu* amphibious assault ship for the TNF. Additionally, Ankara has imported a variety of Spanish military technology and equipment, including aircraft and naval systems, contributing to a generally positive bilateral defence-industrial relationship.

Turkiye is a significant operator of the CASA (now part of Airbus) CN235 aircraft in various configurations,

including transport, maritime patrol and maritime surveillance. The Turkish Air Force, TNF and Turkish Coast Guard collectively operate more than 50 CN235s. The initial contracts were signed in the early 1990s, with the aircraft being produced under licence by TAI. More significantly, Türkiye is a key partner in the Airbus A400M heavy transport aircraft. TAI has played an essential role in the design and production of this transport aircraft, manufacturing parts such as the forward centre fuselage and tailcone for assembly by Airbus at the San Pablo plant in Seville. Türkiye ordered ten A400M planes in 2003, with final delivery completed in 2022. In addition, in 2023, Türkiye began discussions to acquire 40 Eurofighter *Typhoon* fighter jets, following delays in the acquisition of F-16 *Fighting Falcons* from the US.⁵⁸ This highlights Türkiye's ongoing efforts to diversify and modernise its military capabilities.⁵⁹ Recently there have been rumours of an exchange between the two

The TCG *Anadolu* amphibious assault ship, based on Spain's Navantia-designed *Juan Carlos I*, takes part in a naval parade off Northern Cyprus, 20 July 2024



(Dogukan Keskinkilic/Anadolu via Getty Images)

countries involving 24 TAI *Hürjet* jet trainer aircraft in return for six A400Ms, to replace the ageing F-5M trainers in the Spanish Air Force. In this arrangement, Spain would apparently finance the acquisition of these planes through the sale of A400Ms via Airbus, making it a trade transaction between the two countries.⁶⁰

Spain has also cultivated significant relationships in the naval sector. State-owned company Navantia provided design, technology transfer, equipment and technical assistance to Türkiye's Sedef Shipyard for the construction of the amphibious assault ship TCG *Anadolu*. Entering active service in 2023, the *Anadolu* is based on the Spanish Navy's *Juan Carlos I*. Negotiations are under way for a second ship based on the same design.⁶¹ Media sources also highlight ongoing discussions between Navantia and the Turkish government for the supply of new submarines and frigates, with Navantia positioned as the project's technological partner. Notably, a high-level summit in June 2024 addressed potential cooperation in the field of uncrewed underwater vehicles (UUVs) and UAVs, reflecting the evolving nature of defence collaboration between the two states.⁶²

When assessing Türkiye's defence-industrial strengths and weaknesses, specific primary or secondary sources are scarce. However, there is a general consensus within the defence community regarding Türkiye's significant progress, emphasising self-reliance and the development of indigenous technology. Key strengths include advanced UAV technology, the production of armoured vehicles, and a robust defence-manufacturing sector more broadly.⁶³ Despite these advances, Türkiye continues to face challenges, such as reliance on certain foreign components and the need for ongoing technological innovation.

Spain and Türkiye have had disagreements on various foreign-policy issues, including Ankara's military operations in Syria and its maritime claims

in the Eastern Mediterranean. These have occasionally impacted defence cooperation. Aligning with EU policies, Spain has at times limited the sale of specific defence equipment to Türkiye. However, these limitations have generally been situational and specific rather than comprehensive, indicating a nuanced approach to maintaining the balance between cooperation and regulatory compliance.⁶⁴ Spanish recognition of a Palestinian state may help to increase the strategic ties between the two countries, at the expense of weakening the defence-military relationship between Spain and Israel.

The likelihood of continued defence-industrial cooperation between Spain and Türkiye is high, particularly on a bilateral basis in the naval and aerospace sectors.⁶⁵ Both countries could benefit from sharing technological advances and cooperating to achieve greater access to target export markets. Additionally, cooperation could extend to multilateral frameworks within NATO, as both countries are members and can contribute to joint defence initiatives.

Turkish companies are likely to be strong competitors in sectors such as UAVs, armoured vehicles, and naval systems. Türkiye's success in these areas is driven by cost-effective production and robust performance, making their products attractive to a wide range of buyers. As Türkiye continues to enhance its defence-export capabilities, Spanish companies may face competition in markets such as Africa, the Middle East and Southeast Asia, where Türkiye has been actively expanding its defence sales.

Overall, the defence-industrial relationship between Spain and Türkiye is complex, involving a mix of cooperation and competition. Both states have benefitted from past collaboration, and despite occasional political disagreements there is strong potential for future joint projects and mutual growth in the defence sector.

8. United Kingdom

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Like France, the UK has a defence-industrial relationship with Türkiye that dates back to the beginnings of the republic and beyond. Ankara largely stopped acquiring equipment from European states following the end of the Second World War, as the donation of US equipment through the Lend-Lease programme replaced sales by European suppliers, but Türkiye's switch to a JV-based procurement strategy in the 1980s changed this dynamic and created opportunities for UK companies. UK industry success during this period included the supply of communications equipment through Marconi's JV with HAVELSAN, Marconi Kominikasyon (MKAS); armoured vehicles through Shorland's partnership with Otokar; and air-defence systems, such as MBDA's *Rapier* SAM for which production took place in Türkiye with technology transfer to ASELSAN, KALEKALIP and Roketsan.⁶⁶ However, other equipment was also sold directly from UK production lines, such as British Aerospace (BAe) naval radars, BAe Dynamics *Sea Skua* anti-ship missiles and GEC-Marconi *Tigerfish* torpedoes.⁶⁷ BAe was a member of the Future International Military Airlifter industrial effort in the early 1980s that became the European Future Large Aircraft Group in 1991. Türkiye formally committed to buying the resulting A400M in the late 1990s, having been in discussions on the project since the early part of the decade.

As Türkiye's defence-industrial strategy changed from 2004, UK companies found themselves having to adapt their offers. Subsequent defence deals between the two countries were typically characterised either by the localisation of UK designs in Türkiye through technology transfer or by UK support for Turkish design development. Examples of the former included Ultra Electronics' torpedo-defence system for the MilGem corvettes with HAVELSAN, and BAE Systems' display systems for TAI's *Hürkuş* and *Hürjet* aircraft with Fotoniks.⁶⁸

In the latter case, in 2017 BAE Systems won a tender against European competition to support TAI's development of Türkiye's 'fifth generation' National Combat Aircraft (Milli Muharip Uçak, MMU) fighter-aircraft programme, also known as TF-X and now called *Kaan*, up to preliminary design review.⁶⁹ That work has been finished and TAI completed the first flight of the *Kaan* prototype in February 2024. The first *Kaans* will be fitted with the GE Aerospace F110 engine that Turkish company Turkish Engine Industries (TUSAŞ Motor Sanayii, TEI) had previously assembled locally as part of the F-16 licence-production programme. However, Türkiye's highly ambitious power requirements for the *Kaan* will require a new engine. Due to the inherent difficulties of aerospace-engine design, Türkiye has considered partnering with a foreign company, as it did with BAE Systems on the aircraft design. Rolls-Royce established the TAEC JV with Kale Group in 2017 to compete for this requirement against Turkish companies such as TEI.⁷⁰ However, despite a strong push from the UK government and industry, at the time of writing it seems that Türkiye has opted to partner other local firms with Ukraine's Ivchenko-Progress instead.⁷¹

More recently, Türkiye has been negotiating to acquire up to 40 Eurofighter *Typhoon* fighter aircraft. This would represent a major, multi-decade investment in the bilateral relationship with the UK, as well as with the other Eurofighter partner nations. However, as with potential exports of the Eurofighter *Typhoon* to certain other countries, some parts of the German coalition government are hostile to defence exports to Türkiye and are holding up the deal.

The UK–Türkiye industrial engagement has been accompanied by a series of government-to-government agreements on defence. Shortly after taking office in 2010, then-prime minister David Cameron visited Ankara, where he signed a strategic-partnership agreement and made a speech strongly backing Türkiye's EU candidacy, which represented a continuation of previous UK government policy, and calling the relationship

The TAI *Kaan* fighter-aircraft prototype, designed with assistance from BAE Systems, at the 'Debut of the Century of the Future' event in Ankara, 1 May 2023



(Mehmet Kaman/Anadolu Agency via Getty Images)

a 'vital strategic tie'.⁷² This was followed in 2011 by an agreement that set out the terms of future military collaboration, including in industry and procurement, and in 2016 by an agreement governing the sharing of sensitive information.⁷³ More recently, in November 2023, the two countries signed a Statement of Intent (SoI) on defence cooperation during a visit by the UK defence minister to Ankara.⁷⁴ The SoI aims to facilitate greater defence-industrial cooperation, principally through the *Kaan* programme and Türkiye's hoped-for acquisition of *Typhoons* but also through joint exercises in the Eastern Mediterranean and wider security cooperation in the Middle East and North Africa.

UK industrialists assess that Türkiye's defence industry is capable and has benefitted from the value attributed to engineering skills within the education system and in Turkish society more broadly. Strong and consistent UK government engagement with Türkiye on a variety of issues gives industrialists a certain amount of confidence that they can commit time and resources to the Turkish market. Aerospace companies, and particularly TAI, have developed a strong capability in the aerostructures market and are now part of the supply chain for a variety of military and commercial aircraft. Projects involving UK industry are assessed to have

been successful, with companies working well together to navigate technical challenges, albeit sometimes with different approaches to problem-solving and risk tolerance. The SSB is viewed as professional and well suited as an organisation to the defence-industrial strategy that Türkiye is pursuing. The current low value of the lira makes sourcing parts from Turkish industry attractive, although it also makes partnerships with foreign companies more difficult for Turkish firms because of the increased expense in acquiring items from abroad. The 'brain drain' of talented engineers and managers from the country is also seen as an area of weakness. Additionally, Türkiye has a very aggressive offset policy that creates a significant challenge for foreign companies, and indeed there is speculation among British industrialists that Türkiye may soon need to adjust this policy to keep attracting partners.

The UK government assesses Türkiye to be an important partner in European, Middle East and North African security matters through its NATO membership and important bilateral relationships with countries in those regions. High-level visits between London and Ankara have been frequent and for the UK have represented a degree of engagement comparable even to that which it has with key European allies such as France and

Germany. The UK praised Türkiye's role in closing the Bosphorus and Dardanelles straits and brokering the Black Sea grain deal in 2022, and has also been a long-time supporter of Türkiye's fight against the PKK, which London proscribed as a terrorist organisation in 2001, and against the Islamic State (ISIS) more recently. Two British military bases in Cyprus give London a unique interest in relations between Cyprus and Türkiye, and the UK supported the UN reunification proposal in 2004 that was rejected in a referendum by Greek Cypriots.⁷⁵ More recently, the British government has continued to support a peaceful reunification of the island under a 'bi-zonal, bi-communal federation'.⁷⁶ Since the coup attempt in 2016, the UK has engaged with Ankara in a way that is intended to show understanding of Türkiye's internal and external security concerns.⁷⁷ There have been sources of tension, however, including Türkiye's S-400 acquisition and the 2019 *Operation Peace Spring*

in northeastern Syria – after the latter the UK joined with other European states in halting export licences to Türkiye.⁷⁸ In 2020 the UK also enforced EU sanctions against Türkiye due to its gas drilling in waters inside Cyprus's exclusive economic zone.⁷⁹

That Turkish companies are now more competitive is no surprise, and along with the rise of other new competitors, such as South Korea, it makes the market increasingly complex. However, this does not affect UK defence companies' overall strategies, which rely on staying at the cutting edge of technical and engineering practices and offering strong after-sale support that newer defence exporters, as well as some legacy ones, have little or no experience in. In fact, UK government and industry see opportunities to collaborate with Türkiye to achieve mutual export success in markets where Türkiye is now selling equipment, such as Southeast Asia, Central Asia and the Gulf.

Conclusion

Although all European states examined in this report have taken issue, at one time or another, with elements of Türkiye's foreign policy, each has a different approach to engaging with Türkiye in the defence-industrial sector and more broadly. French and UK support for Türkiye's defence requirements can be traced back to the start of the Turkish republic or even further. Dutch, Italian and Spanish activity in the Turkish defence market is more recent but has also been strong, albeit to differing degrees today. Companies from these states have had to adapt their offers over time as Turkish defence-industrial requirements have changed: they have gone from selling equipment directly to Türkiye, to establishing local assembly lines for those systems through JVs with Turkish firms, to supporting Turkish indigenous system development either through design support or the supply of key subsystems.

Following recent export successes, Italy, Spain and the UK maintain a strong interest in the Turkish market. But although there are some examples of Turkish companies working with Italian, Spanish and UK industry to co-develop products for market, it seems likely that most collaboration in the foreseeable future will be solely to meet Turkish requirements, rather than involving Türkiye in a multinational project in the vein of A400M. Meanwhile, engagement from France and the Netherlands is at a low point, with little political support following a series of policy disputes.

By contrast, Poland and Romania, although also disagreeing with some aspects of Turkish activity, are keener to prioritise cooperation because of their proximity to Russia and a desire to involve Ankara in Eastern European and Black Sea security issues. Whereas the other countries in this report have advanced defence industries, Warsaw and Bucharest are at earlier stages in growing their industrial capability, but see Türkiye as a potential partner in that process. This is reciprocated

by Turkish firms, who have shown great interest in the Polish and Romanian markets, albeit with little success to date.

All seven countries assess Türkiye's defence industry to have strong capabilities in key areas such as aerostuctures, electronics and UAVs, even if those with advanced industries do not regard Türkiye's manufacturers as being at the same level. While Türkiye's workforce possesses strong engineering skills and has extensive experience of working with foreign partners, other factors – such as political influence in the domestic procurement process, aggressive technology-transfer and offset requirements, and broader economic troubles – give European industry pause for thought.

A range of policy disagreements concern all of Türkiye's European partners, though they have responded differently in terms of their levels of engagement with Ankara. The most serious disagreements have been over Türkiye's acquisition of the S-400 and its military operations in northeastern Syria, with the former in particular seen as emblematic of Turkish drift away from Western, European and NATO alignment. The other issues include Türkiye's gas exploration in the Eastern Mediterranean and its refusal to recognise the Republic of Cyprus, with the latter particularly damaging to Türkiye's relationship with the EU.

The EU's efforts to incentivise greater defence cooperation among member states, to the deliberate or unintended exclusion of other countries, will inevitably disincentivise working with Türkiye as it is prohibited from participating. This will probably be the case even if an individual EU member state is in favour of cooperating with Türkiye more broadly. Nevertheless, the bilateral approach will remain an important avenue for Türkiye and the countries that wish to cooperate with it, as will utilising organisations such as NATO's NSPA and OCCAR.

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